

https://www.unionleader.com/opinion/op-eds/miriam-janssen-1-of-your-tax-dollar-goes-to-science/article_da4d7a90-fdf6-435d-8607-2750d148ad91.html

Miriam Janssen: 1% of your tax dollar goes to science

Jun 21, 2025

APPROXIMATELY **1% of your tax dollars** are used to fund science research. The Trump administration is **cutting** roughly 40 to 50% percent of this research funding — what does that mean for us?

As a neuroscientist during the COVID-19 pandemic, I was funded by the National Institutes of Health (NIH) working amidst the backdrop of the global scientific community racing to formulate a vaccine. Within 12 months, the **Food and Drug Administration approved** the Pfizer vaccine — a substantial feat considering vaccine research and development typically takes closer to 10 years — underscoring the importance of our scientific systems.





COVID-19 vaccines were formulated by private pharmaceutical companies that relied on fundamental discoveries made by **government-funded scientific research**. Despite political controversy around how to keep communities safe, it is undeniable that the vaccines **saved millions of lives**.

I am now pursuing a Ph.D, this time funded by the National Science Foundation graduate research fellowship program (NSF grfp), studying the brain processes of memory-based learning. By understanding these processes, we may find better treatments for when they become maladaptive (e.g. repetitive thinking of negative events in post-traumatic stress disorder, anxiety, and depression). Considering **one in five Americans** live with mental illness and **9% of high school students** reported seriously contemplating suicide in 2023, both fundamental and applied research are imperative to better understand and treat mental illnesses.

Financial support from NIH and NSF have been essential in my training as a scientist; however, the new administration is attempting to **cut this funding**. The NIH has been forced to pause post-college programs and the NSF grfp **cut their number of awardees** in half. Already there have been reductions in grant funding, rescinded graduate school offers, canceled post-college and graduate programs, as well as mass layoffs at the CDC, NASA, NSF, and NIH. This disruption of scientific progress may not be felt immediately but will have lasting consequences to our economy and public health.

Approximately 1% of your tax dollars are used to fund science research. With this federal support, the NIH directly provides \$132 million and the NSF provides **\$32.6 million of funding** back to research sites in New Hampshire.

For every \$1 invested in research, the United for Medical Research Foundation found a return on investment of \$2.562. They found that the NIH funded more than a thousand jobs in New Hampshire. The Trump administration is severing these investments and pitching it as a way to save you money, but there will be major long-term consequences on economic growth and standards of living.

American University's Institute for Macroeconomic and Policy Analysis **modeled what would happen** to our economy if the U.S. were to cut scientific research and development (R&D) funding such as from NSF, NIH, and NASA. They found a 25% cut to public R&D reduced gross domestic product (GDP) by almost 4% in 25-30 years. A 50% cut to R&D (the amount the Trump administration is proposing in their 2026 budget request) would decrease GDP 8%, resulting in the average American being \$10,000 poorer in their modeled time frame (inflation adjusted to 2023).

New Hampshire health programs are also being targeted by Trump administration cuts. The federal government is attempting to fire 80,000 employees from the Department of Veteran Affairs, which will **significantly disrupt care** for 96,000 New Hampshire veterans on top of significantly raising local unemployment. The **termination of grants** also ended a CDC-sponsored public health epilepsy program at Dartmouth Hitchcock Medical Center that helps individuals across the United States manage their seizure disorder.

Terminating on-going public health programs or active clinical trials not only **jeopardizes data** but the discontinuity of care may worsen participants' conditions. The cuts would impair local quality of life as well as our local impact on a country-wide scale. Additionally, concerning long-term trends in public health persist that deserve federal support. For example, the United States still has the highest rate of **maternal deaths** among high-income countries, which disproportionately affects black mothers. Norway's rate is zero.

Science research is the strongest way we can build a reliable understanding of the world, advance our health and well-being, and predict and plan for future challenges. Your neighborhood scientists are with you and hear you. Our mission is to help communities thrive and prepare to be stronger as we weather the next storm. As an NIH and NSF scientist, I was heartened when researchers came together for public health in 2020. But now that the U.S. scientific system is being gutted, we need your help to rebuild it.

If you feel strongly about this, contact your representatives and let them know you support scientific funding. With enough voices, we may be able to change the proposed 2026 budget and resume scientific and technological funding. Together, we can preserve more than a thousand New Hampshire jobs, continue our public health programs, and work towards a better future.

Miriam A. Janssen is a neuroscience Ph.D. candidate at Dartmouth College. She lives in Lebanon.

Learn more about your privacy options

